THE TEJASHWI TRIAL

OPPORTUNITIES

- His Jan Vishwas Yatra, covering 33 districts of Bihar, focuses on job creation and youth empowerment, countering CM Nitish Kumar's administration
- With an aim to win public goodwill, his speeches during the yatra refrain from playing the victim card despite Nitish's breaking of alliance
- On his agenda is redefining the RJD as a party for all, stressing economic and social justice

THREATS

- Dependence on traditional M-Y vote bank, potentially limiting appeal in a bipolar contest in the upcoming Lok Sabha election
- A resurgent NDA, loss of key allies like Nitish on the Lok Sabha poll eve and Lalu not being in the best health make it challenging to woo additional votes
- Allegations of lawlessness during the Lalu-Rabri regime are being exploited by opponents to tarnish the RJD's image

The Roadblocks

However, even as his yatra is a sign of Tejashwi seizing the moment, the RJD scion's journey is far from over. For one, Nitish's abrupt about-turn, barely a few months before the Lok Sabha election, has somewhat turned back the clock. The current political situation resembles the one that existed in 2019, when Bihar witnessed a bipolar contest in the Lok Sabha polls between the NDA, which included the BJP, JD(U) and Ram Vilas Paswan's Lok Janshakti Party, and the RJD-Congress combine.

With Lalu in judicial custody at the time, Tejashwi had led the RJD's campaign. The party bagged 6.27 million votes, or 15.68 per cent of the valid votes, but failed to win a single seat, registering their worst show. The NDA, on the other hand, won a spectacular 39 of the state's 40 Lok Sabha seats. To add to Tejashwi's current set of challenges, two of their 2019 alliance partners—the Upendra Kushwaha-led Rashtriya Lok Samta Party(RLSP) and the Manjhi-led HAM—are now NDA allies.

But then 2024 is not 2019, and Tejashwi has added several inches to his stature since. Just a year after the Lok Sabha poll debacle, Tejashwi took the reins of his party's campaign for the 2020 assembly election in Bihar and led his party against the formidable alliance of the JD(U) and the BJP, to have the RJD emerge as the single-largest party in the assembly. His alliance fell 12 seats short of a simple majority in the 243-strong Bihar assembly, but the party did manage to improve its vote share to 23.11 per cent.

Another factor working in Tejashwi's favour is that the RJD's core vote base has never deserted Lalu all these years, irrespective of a series of electoral, political and legal setbacks. The party's traditional vote base of Muslims (17.70 per cent) and Yadavs (14.26 per cent), or the M-Y combination, is the alliance's biggest strength. But Tejashwi knows this could well be the RJD's Achilles' heel too—his party does not seem to find favour with other major caste groups. The M-Y support base, though demographically substantial, can be decisive only in triangular or four-cornered contests. In a clear bipolar fight, which is expected to be the case in the coming election, this may just not be enough. The RJD's overdependence on the M-Y vote bank was clear in the 2019 Lok Sabha numbers when the RJD-Congress-RLSP-Vikassheel Insaan Party-HAM alliance together bagged 31.23 per cent of the vote—almost the same strength as its M-Y electorate. Teamed up with Nitish's JD(U), which fetched the *mahagathbandhan* the additional EBC (extremely backward class) vote, the alliance packed quite a punch in the 2015 assembly election. Its alliance with Nitish gave RJD the additional votes in 2015, taking the party's vote share to 44 per cent in the seats that it contested, and helping it become the single-largest party in the assembly.

A Party for All

It's not for nothing, therefore, that Tejashwi is casting his net wide this time. In all his public speeches, he makes it a point to dispel the notion that the RJD is a party of only the Muslims and the Yadavs. At Siwan, for instance, he said, "Our opponents blame us for being an M-Y party. But let me tell you, we have BAAP along with M-Y. BAAP stands for '*Bahujan* (majority), *Agda* (forward castes), *Aadhi Aabadi* (women) and the Poor. No one is left, ours is an A-Z party."

Along with having to project the RJD as more than just an M-Y party, Tejashwi continues to battle the perception, highlighted to the hilt by the BJP and the JD(U), of anarchy during the RJD years. To thwart the constant attempts by the Opposition to remind voters of those 'dark days of Lalu raj', Tejashwi, in meeting after meeting, puts economic and social justice front and centre of his agenda.

In another sign of a clear departure from the past, none of the family members of Mohammad Shahabuddin, the now-deceased don of Siwan, are present at his public meetings. This was unthinkable in the days when Lalu called the shots in the party. The Bihar strongman had fielded Shahabuddin's wife Hena Shahab in three Lok Sabha elections, in 2009, 2014 and 2019.

"*Samay ke saath saath parivartan bhi jaruri hai* (it's necessary to change with time)," he said in Siwan. "There was a time when we had STD booths. Then came the mobile phones, but we still needed to visit shops to get a recharge. Now, we recharge our phones online. *Purana zamana gaya* (the old days are gone)." So perhaps have old ties, one could safely assume. ■